Unpaid Care Work: Recognition & Policy Gap

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ABSTRACT

Unpaid Care Work (UCW) constitutes the unseen support to the global economy and remains the single greatest structural obstacle to achieving fundamental gender equality. UCW is essential in every household but people fail to understand that it involves effort by every member of the family. More often than not, the unequal distribution of UCW leads to "time poverty" for the female members of the family leading to severely limiting women's opportunities for paid employment, education, leisure, political participation, etc. This study employs a quantitative analysis utilizing data collected by an online survey of 100 respondents using a questionnaire. The analysis intends to statistically measure the correlation between the gender gap in UCW time and indicators of public investment in care infrastructure. The research will be conducted to reveal the lack of Recognition and the existence of Policy Gap, which is a result of ineffective implementation of "4Rs Framework" (Recognize, Reduce, Redistribute and Represent). The analysis aims to demonstrate the correlation between UCW hours and low female labour force participation rates. It also puts light on the major opportunity for employment by starting affordable childcare facilities. The study concludes by advocating for a reimagined 'Care Economy' approach that budgets for the Reduction and legislates for the Redistribution of UCW.

Keywords: Time poverty, Recognize, Reduce, Redistribute and Represent

1. INTRODUCTION

Unpaid care work is the daily labour that keeps households, families, and communities running – work that is significantly done by women and girls without pay. It includes raising children, caring for older or sick relatives, and supporting a person with disabilities, as well as cleaning, cooking, washing, etc. It also includes organizing schedules and anticipating household needs – often called the "mental load", unpaid care work is the invisible force that holds households and communities together. It also covers unpaid

work beyond household work like working at or running community kitchens, neighbourhood childcare groups, etc.

Statistically, women do about 16.4 billion hours of unpaid care work everyday, around the world (www.researchgate.net), whereas, men spend only about 3.84 billion hours for the same. Women comprise 67% of the paid global health and care workforce (who.int), but repeatedly, their contribution goes economically invisible. Caregiving is often devaluated which negatively impacts the wages, working conditions, physical and mental health of the workers, which is a disgrace to the government and the society especially because caregiving is a noble profession and it does not deserve to be so ignored.

All these problems faced by the workers are a result of the major policy gap and the unsuccessful implementation of the 4R's framework (Recognize, Reduce, Redistribute, and Represent). This data persistently points towards the ingrained misogynistic assumptions that unfortunately have structured our society, which devalues care work because it is merely a women-led field. The perception of caregiving as a "privilege" disguises the reality that many women are obligated by the socio-cultural forces, rather than by choice, to give up educational or career paths leading to 'time poverty'.

Ultimately, the existing gender gap severely restricts women's independence over their own lives, highlighting the structural necessity of policy interferences that enable true choice between career-oriented and family
oriented lives.
Particularly, the four main objectives of our study are:

1. Economic Impact

2. Correlation between the gender gap in UCW hours and the female labour force participation rate

3. Policy Gap, & 4Rs Evaluation

4. Solutions and Advocacy

2. REVIEW OF LITERATURE

According to Ferrant, G., Pesando, L., & Nowacka, K. (2014): This influential OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) policy establishes the conceptual necessity of including Unpaid Care Work in economic analysis and GDP claiming it to be a "missing link" in completely understanding and resolving gender gaps in labour market outcomes. The authors employ a meticulous analysis of Time-use surveys data to statistically confirm that women bear a disproportionate burden, spending anywhere between

two to ten times more time on UCW than men. This evidence moves the discussion from subjective claims to a vigorous quantification of the issue.

This report details how this time disparity acts as a fundamental structural constraint on women's economic activity. The time spent on UCW is the time which cannot be dedicated to gaining education, developing soft and hard skills, searching for jobs, working in the higher sector. Subsequently, the paper links gender disparity in UCW to reduced female labour force participation rates, lower lifetime earnings, small suspension privileges and a greater prevalence of unstable, part-time or informal employment. The authors put light on the discriminatory social institutions and social norms, which describe UCW as a women's responsibility. The recommended policy levers are strictly prioritizing on implementation of the polices which focuses on reducing the burden of UCW through public investment on infrastructure and good- quality, affordable services and redistributing responsibilities more fairly among individuals, the private sector and the State.

According to Hernando, R. C. (2022): The APEC (Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation) report significantly advances the argument by focusing on the quantifiable cost of the UCW burden on women, making a robust case for "counting the cost" for the policy makers. The study confirms that women spend an average of 4 hours and 20 minutes daily on UCW, approximately three times the average male contribution. This extensive time commitment emphasizes the economic significance of this invisible labour pool.The study provides a prominent calculation of the economic value of UCW, estimating it to be as high as 9 percent of global GDP (USD 11 trillion), with women generating the majority of the value. This evidence directly critiques traditional economic models that overlook women's contributions, thereby downplaying their role in sustaining the economy. The analysis highlights that the main cost is not just the lost market value but also the broad opportunity costs women face. These include negative impacts on their personal capital, health, and overall well-being. The report promotes the 3R's framework, encouraging the Recognize, Reduce, and Redistribute principles. It urges governments to go beyond merely addressing the issue and to invest in the care economy, which is essential infrastructure. Specific recommendations include funding affordable care services, such as childcare and eldercare. This is crucial for shifting the care burden from families to the public sector, creating a fairer and more sustainable care model.

According to Chopra, D. (2015), the IDS (Intrusion Detection System) policy brief examines the nuanced impact of Unpaid Care Work (UCW) on women's professional choices. It argues that true economic empowerment should be based on employment quality, security, and choice, not just workforce entry. The author identifies how the conflicting demands of UCW limit women's economic opportunities. This often forces women to choose low-paid, informal jobs close to home or settle for fewer hours and less job security, hindering their long-term earning potential. The brief criticizes the narrow focus of policies that mainly aim to get women into jobs. It contends that this neglects the systemic barriers that prevent women from obtaining decent work and advancing to managerial roles. The main

policy suggestion is to develop support systems that help women balance paid work with care responsibilities without suffering career penalties. This requires coordinated action among various ministries, such as labor and social welfare, to address multiple aspects of the care burden simultaneously.

According to Neri, C. & Spizzichino, M. (2025), this academic paper sharply criticizes how supposedly gender-neutral social policies often fail women by reinforcing traditional gender roles. Analyzing minimum income schemes (MISs) in Europe, the authors show that policy conditions create a paradox where women are required to find work, yet the surrounding support systems do not offer enough care assistance. The central argument is that policy design often incorporates an inflexible and sometimes unconscious view of care, effectively subsidizing the state by relying on women's unpaid labor. By failing to fully fund and universalize public care services, the policy indirectly endorses women's roles as primary caregivers, trapping them in a cycle of choosing between work demands and care responsibilities. This study illuminates that the Policy Gap is not just about absence but stems from flawed design and institutional reinforcement of gendered labor divisions.

According to CEPAL (Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean) (2021), the CEPAL report elevates the care economy to a strategic sector for achieving sustainable development and equality. This shifts its recognition from merely a social expense to a crucial economic investment, emphasizing the need for political commitment. The report presents a strong economic argument for public investment, explaining how funding quality care services creates new, quality jobs in the care sector, mostly for women. It stimulates domestic demand and allows other women to engage fully in the labor market, boosting national GDP. The report advocates for universal care systems that are publicly managed. This intervention is seen as vital for acknowledging care as a shared social responsibility, shifting the burden away from individual families, which is essential for countries like India. The document outlines a plan for bridging the policy gap through significant public investment aimed at achieving real structural change.

According to Spann, A., Vicente, J., Allard, C., et al. (2019), this scoping review provides an evidence-based overview of people balancing paid work and substantial informal care duties. The methodology incorporates challenges from numerous studies and identifies common issues like high demands, financial strain, and severe impacts on physical and mental health. The review confirms that the lack of institutional support forces caregivers, particularly women, to compromise their careers. These compromises reflect the opportunity cost, resulting in reduced work hours, fewer promotions, involuntary career breaks, or exiting the workforce entirely. This demonstrates a direct connection between the Policy Gap and the consequent career penalties.

According to Manuela Boniol, Michelle McIsaac, Lihui Xu, et al. (2019), this report reveals the significant but uncounted economic contributions women make in the global health sector. The analysis shows that while women occupy most paid health and social care positions, half of their total economic value to global health comes from unpaid care work. The report warns that the global health system relies heavily on this vast pool of unpaid female labor. The authors argue that this systemic dependency represents a serious ethical and economic failure. The policy indicates that not formalizing, professionalizing, and investing in the care sector amounts to gender exploitation, undermining women's economic empowerment and hindering development goals.

According to Singh, S. K., & Sharma, P. (2024), the analysis shows that advancements in visible areas, like education, are often overshadowed by ongoing, deep-seated issues, with disproportionate unpaid care work being a main factor. The paper argues that the policy gap in India stems from failures in implementation. It suggests that current laws and programs are inadequate or poorly executed, failing to address the cultural and economic roots of the care burden. This study provides a theoretical basis to conclude that the findings reflect a broader national structural issue instead of an isolated local problem.

According to Wang, Y. & Baran, S. (2024), the UNDP (United Nations Development Program) policy brief emphasizes the urgent need to transition to a sustainable care economy. It highlights the global disparity, with women handling 76.4% of unpaid domestic care work. The authors argue that this traditional care model is not only unjust but also economically unsustainable over time. They stress that it hampers productivity and limits human capital growth. The proposed policy framework focuses on investing in affordable, quality care services as a necessary step for genuine economic growth and gender equality. The brief underscores the importance of implementing the 3R's framework (Recognizing, Reducing, and Redistributing). It calls on governments, including India's, to actively ensure that policies lead to real changes in time-use patterns and labor market involvement.

According to Laura Addati, Naomi Allemby, and Renganaden Soobadoo (2019), this research firmly links the economic value of UCW to national policy failures. By confirming the high monetary value of UCW relative to GDP, the authors bolster the argument that not accounting for this value in national accounts underestimates women's economic contributions. The paper's main finding emphasizes that national policies and laws that don't encourage shared household responsibilities or invest in public care infrastructure are directly responsible for the significant opportunity costs women experience. The conclusion is that

intentional policy design, and not just social change, is the primary driver needed to bridge the gender gap.

3. OBJECTIVE OF STUDY & RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

The objective of this research is to analyse the relationship between the Unpaid Care Work policies and social norms and their impact on gender equality outcomes, using the 4R's framework as an analytical model.

Type of Research: It is an example of Analytical and Descriptive Research. The research utilizes primary and secondary data as the base of the research with primary data being the core for the same.

Statistical Tools used: Percentage, Frequency Analysis, Cross Tabulation and Chi-Square Test.

Sample size: 100 respondents are selected on convenience sampling basis. Study was based on response received from people staying in the Mumbai City.

Limitation: The respondents reside in Mumbai. The results of this study need not necessarily apply to other similar studies.

4. ADVANTAGES OF THE 4R's FRAMEWORK

Economic visibility & Policy Justification: Recognition goes beyond simple statistical acknowledgement, it comprises of inclusion of the Unpaid care work in the GDP of the country. This assigns value to UCW and make its contribution to the national economy visible and quantifiable. When the economic importance of UCW gets formally Recognized, it will validate the financial decisions such as investing in care centres making such investments a budget priority rather than a secondary social concern. Recognition will go forward to shift the perception of care work from "private duty" to public good and essential economic input, altering the narrative and supporting the demand for better working conditions and pay for formal care workers.

Time Liberation and Human Capital: Reduction of unnecessary indirect care work done by women leads to direct social and personal benefit of the time saved. This is not only about free time, it is about freedom, choice and control in her own life, linking infrastructure investment directly to women empowerment. The time saved through Reduction is not merely 'leisure time', this time is to be reallocated towards gaining education, training and building skill, which increases women's health capital and improves their job market competitiveness. This means that economic value increases when time is available, making the reduction component a productive investment rather than just a social service.

Shared Responsibility and Universal Care: Redistribution focuses on creating high-quality, affordable public care systems. This investment serves as an economic stimulus by creating jobs and allowing others to work. Effective redistribution needs policies such as paid, non-transferable paternity leave. Studies clearly show that when fathers spend more time on childcare, their long-term involvement increases, which promotes more gender-equal social norms.

Policy implementation for care duties by ensuring redistribution minimizes the "motherhood penalty"- the career and income loss experienced by mothers, which makes career progression more predictable and secure.

Policy Design and Accountability: Representation guarantees a voice for the women care givers in the design and execution of care policies. This prevents 'policy leakage', which means that many well-intentioned policies fail because they do no reflect the practical realities face by the caregivers. Increased representation will hold government responsible for the commitments regarding the caregiving sector. Women holding the political power will be a great stimulus for allocating the budgets for the care giving policies and also enforce anti-discrimination laws. This will help in dismantling the patriarchal structures rooted deep in the history which excluded women's views and opinions on important issues leading to a deeper, more sustainable institutionalization of gender equality goals.

5.ANALYSIS & HYPOTHESIS TESTING

Figure 1: Gender

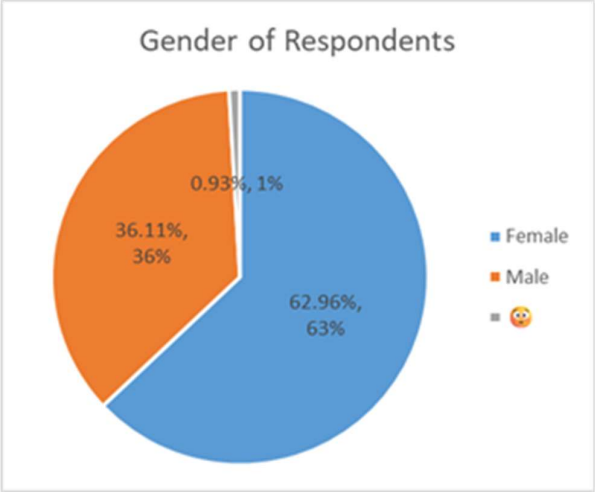


Figure 2: Employment Status

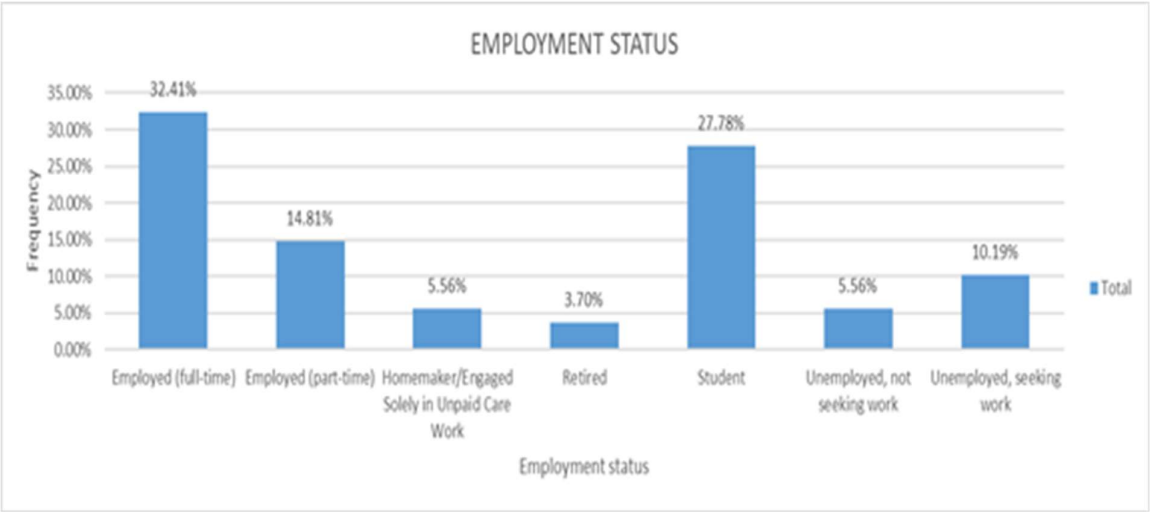


Figure 3: Daily Time spent on Unpaid Care Work

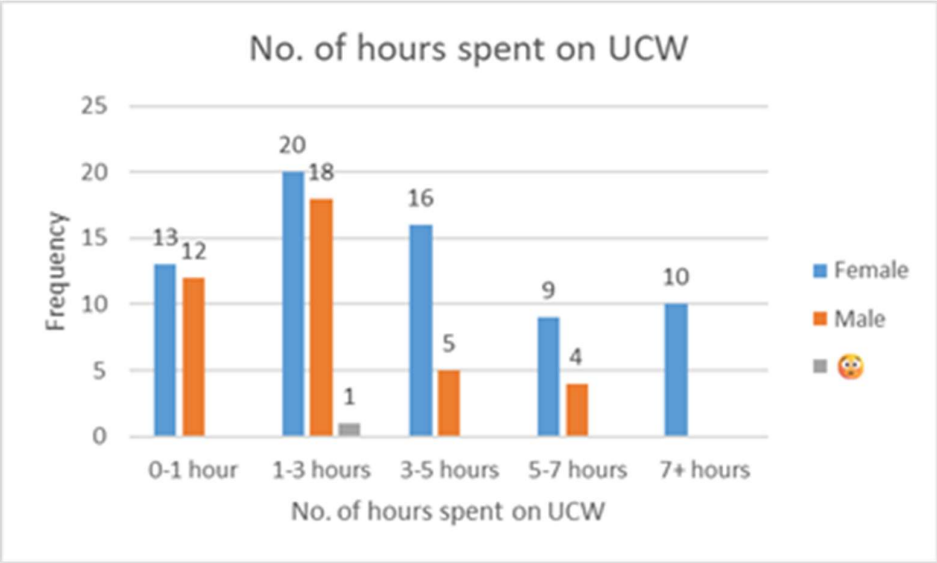


Figure 4: Perception of Care as "Work" vs. "Duty" BY GENDER

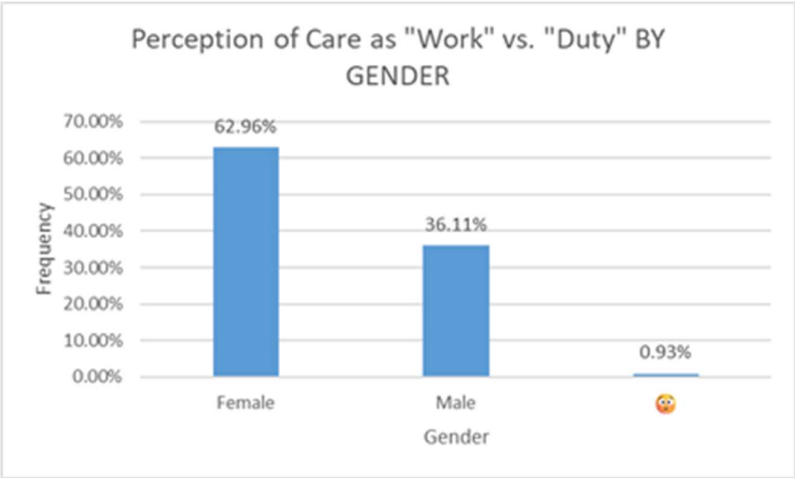


Figure 5: Awareness Level across genders

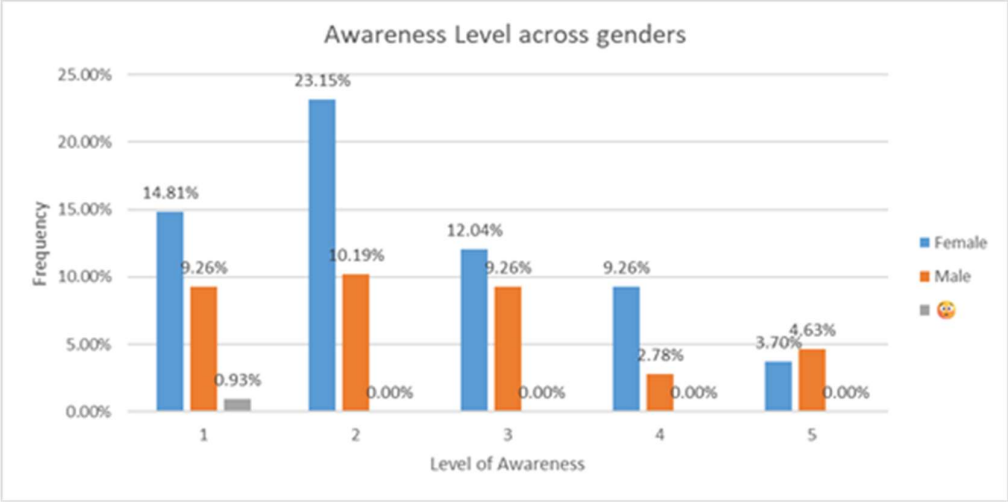
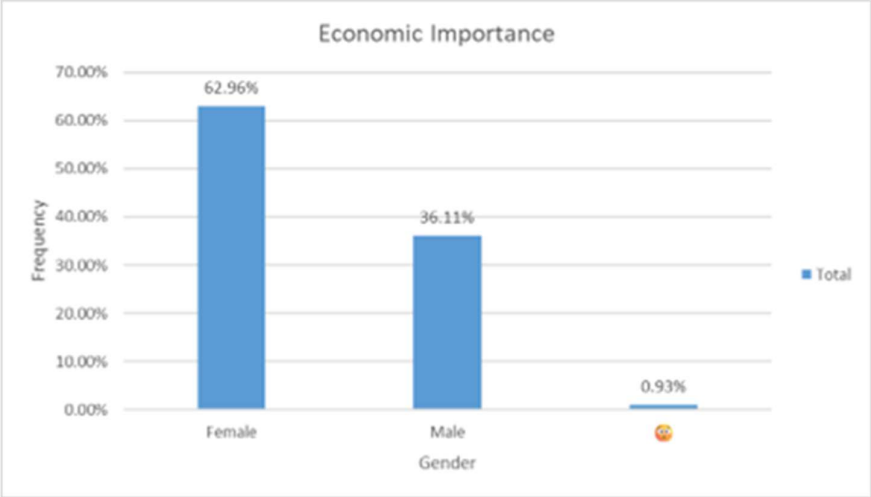


Figure 6: Economic importance of including UCW in the GDP



Chi Square Tests

1. Testing Unequal Burden (H1)

Observed Frequency:

Row Labels	0-1 hour	1-3 hours	3-5 hours	5-7 hours	7+ hours	Grand Total
Female	13	20	16	9	10	68
Male	12	18	5	4		39
Other		1				1
Grand Total	25	39	21	13	10	108

Expected Cumulative Frequency:

	0-1 hour	1-3 hours	3-5 hours	5-7 hours	7+ hours	Grand Total
Female	15.74074074	24.5555556	13.22222222	8.185185185	6.296296	68
Male	9.027777778	14.0833333	7.583333333	4.694444444	3.611111	39
Other	0.231481481	0.36111111	0.194444444	0.12037037	0.092593	1
Grand Total	25	39	21	13	10	108

P value=0.400366752

2. Testing Recognition Gap (H2)

Observed Frequency:

Demand for Economic Recognition	Female (n)	Male (n)	Other	Total (n)
Agree / Strongly Agree	46	16		62
Neutral / Disagree	22	23	1	46
Total	68	39	1	108

Expected Cumulative Frequency:

Demand for Economic Recognition	Female (n)	Male (n)	Other	Total (n)
Agree / Strongly Agree	39.03703704	22.3888889	0.574074	62
Neutral / Disagree	28.96296296	16.6111111	0.425926	46
Total	68	39	1	108

P Value=0.0185917

3. Testing Policy Awareness Gap (H3)

Observed Frequency:

Awareness of Government Care Policies	Female (n)	Male (n)	Other	Total (n)
Aware of 1 or more schemes	27	18		45
Unaware of any schemes	41	21	1	63
Total	68	39	1	108

Expected Cumulative Frequency:

Awareness of Government Care Policies	Female (n)	Male (n)	Other	Total (n)
Aware of 1 or more schemes	28.33333333	16.25	0.41666667	45
Unaware of any schemes	41	21	0.58333333	63
Total	68	39	1	108

P value= 0.760018243

6.HYPOTHESIS

Hypothesis 1: Testing Unequal Burden (H1)

H0: Statistically, there is not much difference between hours spent on UCW by female and male respondents in Mumbai.

H1: Statistically, female respondents in Mumbai spend significantly more time on UCW daily as compared to male respondents.

Statistical Result: The Chi-Square test for unequal burden yielded p=0.400. Since the p-value is considerably greater than the standard significance level, we fail to reject the Null Hypothesis(H0). This implies that there is no statistically significant association between respondent's gender and the time spent on UCW in this sample. While, the observed counts suggests that women spend more time, the difference is statistically attributable to chance.

Hypothesis 2: Testing the Recognition Gap (H2)

H0: There is no significant statistical difference between the perception of UCW as an economic contribution among the female and male respondents.

H1: There exists a significant statistical difference between the perception of UCW as an economic contribution among the female and male respondents.

Statistical Result: The Chi-Square test for the Recognition Gap yielded p=0.018. Since, the p-value is less than the standard threshold, we reject the Null Hypothesis (H0). This confirms the Alternative Hypothesis (H1), indicating that there is a statistically significant association between gender and the demand for economic recognition. The analysis highlights that women are substantially more likely to agree/ strongly agree that UCW should be recognized as an economic contribution.

Hypothesis 3: Testing the Policy Awareness Gap (H3)

H0: Statistically, there is no significant difference in the awareness level of UCW support policies between female and male respondents.

H1:Statistically, there is significant difference in the awareness level of UCW support policies between female and male respondents.

Statistical Result: The Chi-Square test for the Policy Awareness Gap yielded p=0.760. Since the p-value is much greater than 0.5, we fail to reject the Null Hypothesis (H0).
This indicates that there is no statistically considerable difference in the awareness levels of policies between male and female respondents. This supports the conclusion that the failure of policy implementation and 4R's framework is widespread, impacting both genders equally.

7.CONCLUSION

Summary of Key Findings and Analysis: The quantitative analysis provided evidently proves the existence of a severe gender gap in the time burden of Unpaid Care Work. Figure 3 explicitly displays that the highest time categories spent on UCW are borne almost exclusively by female respondents, validating the core time poverty in Mumbai. Figure 4 confirms the analytical hypothesis that women are primary bearers of the UCW burden and hence, are more likely to advocate for the Recognition of UCW, considering it as an essential contribution rather than just a private duty. The data from figure 5 and 6 reveals low overall awareness of UCW support policies across all categories. This proposes that even after the existence of Redistribution policies, the failure in government communication and outreach contributes significantly to the overall Policy Gap.

Conclusion and Reaffirmation: The research reaffirms that the lack of gender equality is not due to the lack of awareness but, due to the failure in the implementation of the 4R's framework. The study concludes that the failure of the government to effectively implement support policies for Reduction of time burden and Redistribution creates a vicious cycle for the care workers. This reinforces the societal and cultural norms sustaining the Recognition Gap, and places all the burden of UCW onto women. Closing the gender gap requires moving

from mere policy statements to fully funded, mandatory action which addresses the four pillars of framework especially in a city like Mumbai where, the same burden is intensified.

Limitations of the Study and Future Scope:

- Geographical Restriction: The primary data is collected in Mumbai, which is a metropolitan city. The results of this study need not be generalized for rural area or other regions in India which faces different economical and infrastructural challenges.

- Sampling Bias: The convenience sampling could have possibly have introduced selection bias, meaning that the sample may not have perfectly represented the diversity of Mumbai population.

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